

NORTH BY NORTH-EAST

Instead of permanent dispensation as special category states, the North-East needs better infrastructure to complement its already strong social fabric for better integration

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Most people generalise about the North-East states of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim and Tripura (Sikkim is not one of the Seven Sisters). Though there is shared common history (many, but not all, states were carved out of former Assam) and shared infrastructural problems like Chicken's Neck (a narrow stretch of land which connects the north-eastern states to the rest of India), there are significant inter-state variations, often ignored in mainstream Indian attitudes.

Data is frequently unavailable. When it is, data for Assam is applied to the rest of the North-East (for instance, the Planning Commission does this for poverty ratios). Under Article 371, special dispensation is available to Arunachal, Assam, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland and Sikkim. These parts of the Constitution were meant to be temporary and transitional. But the North-East receives permanent dispensation as special category states. While this ensures Central subsidies, it also ensures permanent segregation (at various points, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Goa, and Andhra Pradesh were also covered by Article 371). Historically, the North-East's ties were with Bhutan, Myanmar and China. These were cut off under the British rule and resumed after Independence. Permanent integration requires ties with Bangladesh, Bhutan, China,

SOME NORTH-EASTERN STATES HAVE HIGH AFFLUENCE LEVELS. THIS COULD BE DUE TO THE SPECIAL CATEGORY STATUS WHICH ENSURES CENTRAL FUNDS.

Myanmar, Nepal and Thailand. This is equally true of better road infrastructure (bane of the hills) and flood control (bane of the Brahmaputra valley).

Arunachal Pradesh has a population density of 13 per sq km and a literacy rate of 60 per cent as per National Sample Survey Organisation's (NSSO) 2004-05 data. In the past 10 years, its real GDP (state domestic product) has increased by 14.2 per cent in 1995-96, but also declined by 4.9 per cent in 1996-97. Assam has a population of 26.7 million and a literacy rate of 71 per cent. Real GDP growth in Assam has ranged between a decline of 0.2 per cent in 1998-99 and an increase of 6.1 per cent in 2001-02. Today it is difficult to believe that in the early 1950s, Assam's per capita income was higher than the all-India average and that the world's second oldest oil-well still functions here. Post-1991, Assam's growth has been well below the

BETTER THAN THE REST

Nagaland is number 2 in the north-eastern region in terms of per capita income even though it has the lowest agricultural yield and has the worst sex ratio

STATES	Agri Yield (kg/ha)	Literacy (%)	Primary education*	Sex ratio	Per capita income (Rs)
ARUNACHAL PRADESH	1,342	60	49.10	919	20,306
ASSAM	1,466	71	58.76	937	15,219
MANIPUR	2,270	75	69.29	975	16,292
MEGHALAYA	1,767	77	57.79	913	19,856
MIZORAM	1,816	89	82.91	892	27,733
NAGALAND	1,322	78	75.15	891	27,058
SIKKIM	1,451	75	55.03	972	24,740
TRIPURA	2,033	74	55.25	975	22,752

* percentage of 10-plus children who have completed schooling till Class V